

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

PIA3142 | WEEK 3: IDENTITY, RATIONALITY, EMOTIONS

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

Last week we explored theoretical approaches to social movements, including those that focus on individual deprivation or rationality as well as those that provide more or less "structural" solutions to what we called "the collective action problem."

We went over Theda Skocpol's "non-voluntaristic" approach to "social revolutions," as well as Doug McAdam, Sidney Tarrow, and Charles Tilly's (McTT) "political opportunity structure" approach.

P.O.S. mixes an interest in the structural conditions that help determine whether social movements emerge, what form they take, and whether they succeed with attention to agency and choice—insights about the way social movements employ resources and "cognitive frames" to get followers to join their cause.

OPPORTUNITY STRUCTURES

To recap, the P.O.S. approach emphasizes:

(1.) Political opportunities and constraints: Structural factors that make dissidents more/less likely to act, or create more/less favorable circumstances for the success of mobilization.

(2.) Mobilization structures: The capacity to put together hierarchical organizations that establish trust, mobilize resources (organizational, leadership, symbolic/cultural, financial, intellectual, etc.), coordinate action.

(3.) Cognitive frames: The capacity of leaders to "frame" their appeals effectively in order to convince supporters of the need to protest and the likely success of it. Here, recourse to ideology and the ability to construct a narrative for a movement's sense of historical purpose/mission is key, as are the words chosen to inspire people to participate.

CRITIQUES

While the approach is more sophisticated, focusing on political opportunities presents similar problems as relative deprivation.

[i] In retrospect, proponents can always begin with a social movement and look back at the opportunity that *caused* it to succeed. This is a bit like assuming the answer: the analytical strategy makes sense only if one is already convinced that political opportunities *are* the cause.

Proponents have yet to specify precise features that make it possible to identify political opportunities independently of the outcome (i.e., "to know one when one sees one"); the tendency is to classify developments as opportunities only in retrospect.

CRITIQUES

[ii] This poses another problem. If political opportunities are defined by objective criteria, it is likely that in most instances one sees no exact correspondence with action (e.g., elite divisions don't always cause protest).

In this case, P.O.S. theorists might explain negative cases (no mobilization) by finding a reason why the group's resources/framing was not effective. Again, this tends to assume the answer.

Again, the problem is that the approach does not provide a mechanism for the mobilization of individuals; the argument that opportunities decrease the costs of participation is not much of a solution for the collective action problem.

CRITIQUES

A fix might be to say that political opportunities only matter when they are perceived as such (just like deprivation matters only when felt as such).

But, this also raises the question of whether it is even useful to think in terms of structurally created opportunities, as followers can be made to feel that opportunities (just like grievances) exist regardless of objective conditions.

Then, the question becomes not which opportunities/grievances lead to action, but how participants come to perceive them, as a result of mobilization (what social movement organizations/leaders say or do to encourage participation), and how they are motivated to take action on that basis, perhaps at times against self-interest.

CRITIQUES

This reasoning calls into question the importance of structure. This is not to say that class relations, international context, elite divisions, and macro-historical processes like state formation or nation building don't matter.

In fact, they do matter because they set obstacles that the leaders of social movements face and the options available to them (e.g., there will be no peasant revolution in advanced industrial societies), making different outcomes more or less *likely* at the outset.

But, structure does not *wholly* determine outcomes, which are sensitive to both choice and chance, rendering specific outbreaks of protest unpredictable.

CRITIQUES

In each specific instance, what determines the outcome is how leaders respond to the challenges/incentives/constraints provided by structure, their success in motivating followers, and the results of their strategic interactions with the state or other targets of protest.

That means that tactical/strategic aspects are key (Week 4).

Moreover, this consideration brings us back to the question:

How is the collective action problem, which works against individual participation, solved by social movements?

That is the subject of today's class.

THE SOLUTION

The key to the solution of the “collective action problem” is to return to the individual, but in a way that supplement focus on self-interest with focus on the instinctive, emotional, and moral bases of action, paying attention to how the mobilization of resources and a movement’s framing activities activate certain psychological mechanisms/processes.

Another key is to consider individuals not in isolation, but as embedded in a web of social relations (family, friends, school, work, political/social/communal organizations, class, ethnicity, region, etc.) through which one acquires certain preferences, values, worldviews, and identities. These communities also shape individual action by administering social and psychological rewards or costs for different behaviours.

THE SOLUTION

Concept of “Methodological Individualism”:

Explanations in the social sciences should refer to individuals; there is no such thing as “collective behavior;” all collective behavior is an aggregation of decisions/actions taken by individuals.

That means that explaining the behavior of groups requires an explanation for the behavior of individuals within those groups.

Explanations of individual behavior, in turn, should take the form of “intentional explanation:” Key feature of “intentionality” is that humans behave in a goal-oriented way, on the basis of some “desires” or “motivations” as well as some “beliefs” about the world around them.

THE SOLUTION

Methodological individualism tends to be associated with "rational choice theory," which explains behavior by focusing on "instrumental rationality" (remember "Jane's Dilemma").

"Instrumental rationality" means that individuals seek to maximize "utility" (i.e., maximize their enjoyment of goods/activities they value, based on their individual preferences).

What these preferences are does not matter to whether someone acts "rationally;" what matters is that individuals make choices by estimating the consequences that the different choices/actions have for "utility"—they maximize "expected utility" by estimating the potential "payoff" of different courses of action and the probability with which such actions will actually generate such payoffs.

THE SOLUTION

A “strong” version of rationality only admits “self-interest” as a motivation: a behavior is rational only if it maximizes self-interest (improves one’s own situation in some tangible way).

People, however, don’t always behave in their self-interest: emotions tend to color beliefs/decisions, pursuit of other-regarding. public goals also often comes at expense of self-interest.

This is not necessarily “irrational:” 1) Often sensitive to interest (won’t do it if costs are too high); 2) If one draws some psychological benefit from actions taken against material interest, actions are still “rational” (preferences v. behavior).

THE SOLUTION

This is a “weaker” version of rationality. It is more “realistic” but a great deal less useful (potentially, almost anything may be construed as “rational” once the notion is de-coupled from material self-interest).

Either way, the key to “methodological individualism” is to explain individual behavior in terms of someone’s:

a) “Desires” or “motivations,” whether self-interested or not;

b) “Beliefs” involve thoughts about how the world works, expectations about the behavior of others, and estimations of the potential that certain actions will satisfy one’s “desires”.

MOTIVATIONS

What, other than self-interest, motivates behavior?

1. Human beings are animated by passions or emotions. There are at least two ways of conceiving their impact on individual behavior:

a) Some emotions, like anger or fear, have “action tendencies:” meaning, they predispose an individual to take a particular action.

b) Human beings take actions designed to “pursue” pleasurable emotions and avoid unpleasant ones: e.g., conformist behaviour is generally explained by the desire to “fit in,” by which one seeks reassurance of his/her own adequacy. Perhaps most important, people care a great deal about their self-image and their public reputation. The desire to uphold them can often lead them to think not very rationally (e.g., self-deception) and act in ways that contradict material self-interest (e.g., do something prideful at great personal cost).

EMOTIONS

The reading for this week distinguishes between four kinds of emotions that are relevant to collective mobilization: reflex emotions, affective emotions, moods, and moral emotions.

REFLEX EMOTIONS are things like fear, surprise, anger, disgust, joy, sadness. These are emotions that arise "without conscious cognitive processing," involuntarily.

These emotions matter in two ways: a) With supporters: instilling fear, anger, disgust, joy, sadness, getting them to react in similar ways to similar stimuli; b) With opponents: strategies may be designed to get opponents (other movements, the state, the police, etc.) to react out of anger/fear in a way that helps to discredit them.

EMOTIONS

AFFECTIVE EMOTIONS are things like love, hate, respect, and trust. Creating "affects" involves getting followers into making positive/negative psychological investments in different people, places, ideas, etc.

Affects require more work to be formed, but last longer, do not subside easily.

Key because affects "give us our basic orientations toward the world, especially telling us what we care most deeply about".

Things like love/hate can motivate action, increase benefits of participation (psychological benefits); instilling respect/trust key to shaping beliefs, also may form predispositions for reflex emotions when confronted with certain events.

EMOTIONS

MOODS are “transportable emotions” (from one situation to the next). Social movements motivate followers by instilling hope, optimism, confidence in individual/collective efficacy (convince them their actions make more of a difference than they really do).

MORAL EMOTIONS are things like feelings of pride, shame, guilt, compassion, indignation. All involve moral judgments (of oneself/others) that come from one’s comprehension of the world and one’s place in it. Can interfere with decision-making process by providing benefits for actions that generate pride, costs for actions that generate guilt/shame, or inducing one to discount costs/benefits of action when compassion/indignation are intense enough.

MOTIVATIONS

2. Human beings have a natural impulse to engage in “self-categorization” (i.e., define their identity in terms of group membership) and practice “parochial altruism” (i.e., favor people, even unknown people, seen as members of the same group, discriminate against others).

This, perhaps combined with the desire to uphold one’s self-image or public reputation, renders us capable of great sacrifices when it comes to advancing perceived interests of “our” groups, great savagery when it comes to defending “our” groups from outside threat (note that perception of interests/threat can be manipulated).

J. Haidt calls this the “Hive Switch,” noting people are “90% Chimp, 10% Bee.” Most of our lives are taken up by petty concerns of self-interest; under some conditions, however, we have an ability to “lose ourselves in something larger,” where the self tends to disappear and collective interests dominate. Even when engaged in daily lives, we are often “nagged” by a sense that there is some higher/nobler (collective) purpose out there for us.

ORWELL ON HITLER

Check out this quote by George Orwell, from his 1940 review of Adolf Hitler's book *Mein Kampf*:

"[Hitler] has grasped the falsity of the hedonistic attitude to life. Nearly all western thought since the last war, certainly all 'progressive' thought, has assumed tacitly that human beings desire nothing beyond ease, security and avoidance of pain. In such a view of life there is no room, for instance, for patriotism and military virtues. The Socialist who finds his children playing with soldiers is usually upset, but he is never able to think of a substitute for the tin soldiers; tin pacifists somehow won't do. Hitler, because in his own joyless mind he feels it with exceptional strength, knows that human beings don't only want comfort, safety, short working-hours, hygiene, birth-control and, in general, common sense; they also, at least intermittently, want struggle and self-sacrifice, not to mention drums, flags and loyalty-parades.

ORWELL ON HITLER

However they may be as economic theories, Fascism and Nazism are psychologically far sounder than any hedonistic conception of life. The same is probably true of Stalin's militarised version of Socialism. All three of the great dictators have enhanced their power by imposing intolerable burdens on their peoples. Whereas Socialism, and even capitalism in a more grudging way, have said to people 'I offer you a good time', Hitler has said to them 'I offer you struggle, danger and death', and as a result a whole nation flings itself at his feet. Perhaps later on they will get sick of it and change their minds, as at the end of the last war. After a few years of slaughter and starvation 'Greatest happiness of the greatest number' is a good slogan, but at this moment 'Better an end with horror than a horror without end' is a winner. Now that we are fighting against the man who coined it, we ought not to underrate its emotional appeal."

BELIEFS

Note that, just as motivations may extend beyond self-interest, beliefs are often not formed in a "rational" fashion, based on objective assessments of reality (which are needed to pursue self-interest through cost/benefit calculus). Most commonly, beliefs are biased by the desires themselves.

"Social categorization" and "parochial altruism" have as strong an impact on beliefs as they have on motivations.

Haidt (2012: xxxiii) writes: "People bind themselves into political teams that share moral narratives. Once they accept a particular narrative, they become blind to alternative moral worlds."

"Morality," as Haidt (2012: 217) puts it, "binds and blinds," as the moral beliefs we hold, important as they are to the cohesiveness of our social groups, drive our perceptions of reality and blind us to disconfirming evidence and logic

THE SOLUTION

The key point, for our purposes, is that the “desires” and “beliefs” that drive individual action are to some extent “endogenous” to the process of mobilization.

Individuals targeted for mobilization in a movement have “exogenous” desires and beliefs (exogenous means “having external causes”).

However, the activities in which a social movement engages (use of rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals, etc.) can re-shape an individual’s pre-existing desires and beliefs, thereby changing one’s predisposition for action.

The success of mobilization often depends on these activities.

THE SOLUTION

The effort of a social movement to re-shape individual motivations and beliefs can take place both directly and indirectly.

Directly, a movement might attempt to re-shape people's desires by working on:

1) Interests (persuading people that their personal and collective interests are the same, or changing perceptions of what those interests are);

2) Passions (creating emotional urges to act a certain way or cut short the thinking process about the consequences of actions; or get people to attach certain emotional rewards to certain actions);

3) Reason (convincing people of justice of the cause and its worthiness of great personal sacrifice).

THE SOLUTION

Also, a movement can try directly to re-shape beliefs, involving:

1) Wishful thinking (exaggerate perceived chances of success, as well as probability that individual participation will make a difference; or, minimize perception of real risks/costs of participation);

2) Counter-wishful thinking (increasing perception of risks/ costs of non-participation, such as inducing people to fear social sanction from doing nothing, convincing them that they will be personally blamed by the group to which they belong, or their descendants, or even the "judgment of history" for the failure of the movement).

THE SOLUTION

The success of these efforts, however, depends on how well the movement has laid the groundwork, indirectly, by getting a participant to feel in some way "bound" to the movement and its members, as well as to define his/her sense of self based on membership in the movement.

The process of creating, among followers, the values that lead to the "moral emotions" and "moods" that impel action, the "affective bonds" by which people develop commitments to friends/foes, and the predisposition to react to events with predictable "reflexes" is often a matter of fostering "collective identities."

"Collective identities" are socially constructed (not objective or given) and largely imagined (one can feel bound to others he/she does not know personally). They are the sources of solidarities, values, and self-images, whose affirmation can motivate action—e.g., "I do this because this is who I am" or "I do this to defend my sense of dignity" or "I do this to earn the recognition I/we deserve."

IDENTITY WORK

1. SETTING BOUNDARIES: “Social, psychological, or physical structures that establish differences between a challenging group and a dominant group.” Involves “marking social territory” to accentuate differences between participants and non-participants. What distinguishes people within/outside the boundaries can be almost anything.

This may involve creation of new identities; more commonly, groups seek to leverage pre-existing identities (and solidarity networks that facilitate mobilization), convincing individuals belonging to various groups to regard engagement in the movement as consistent with their existing sense of self, then to add to or modify such identities to enhance congruence with the movement and bridge between the pre-existing identities of various groups targeted for incorporation.

IDENTITY WORK

2. BUILDING CONSCIOUSNESS: Involves the creation of a “movement narrative” that can foster, among participants, a common consciousness consisting of a common set of values, grievances, goals, and sense of historical mission. Common consciousness aids mobilization to the extent that:

a) It results in members of the group interpreting and responding to certain events or state of affairs in a similar way, through common understanding of past and present.

b) It binds individual participants to the movement and each other, perhaps to the point that they come to see their own lives or place in the world as being defined (at least in part) by their identification with and participation in the movement.

IDENTITY WORK

Often, setting boundaries or building consciousness involves the use symbols and rituals—sometimes new, sometimes old, sometimes old repurposed or redeployed for new purposes.

Symbols/rituals serve to:

a) Accentuate differences between participants and non- participants;

b) Increase, among participants, a sense of loyalty and solidarity with the movement and other participants;

c) Attract the attention of outsiders (appeal to some non- participants to join in, get media attention).

IDENTITY WORK

Identification with a collectivity affects individual action/participation through the emotions it engenders and their effects on individual desires/beliefs. Identification with a movement or cause can serve to strengthen:

a) Moods of optimism, hope, and efficacy;

b) Affects like love, hate, respect, and trust;

c) Moral emotions like pride, shame, guilt, compassion, and indignation.

These emotions, in turn, can modify cost/benefit calculations, create visceral urges that induce participants to eschew or truncate cost/benefit calculations, or condition individuals to consider the group's interest above one's own.

WARNING

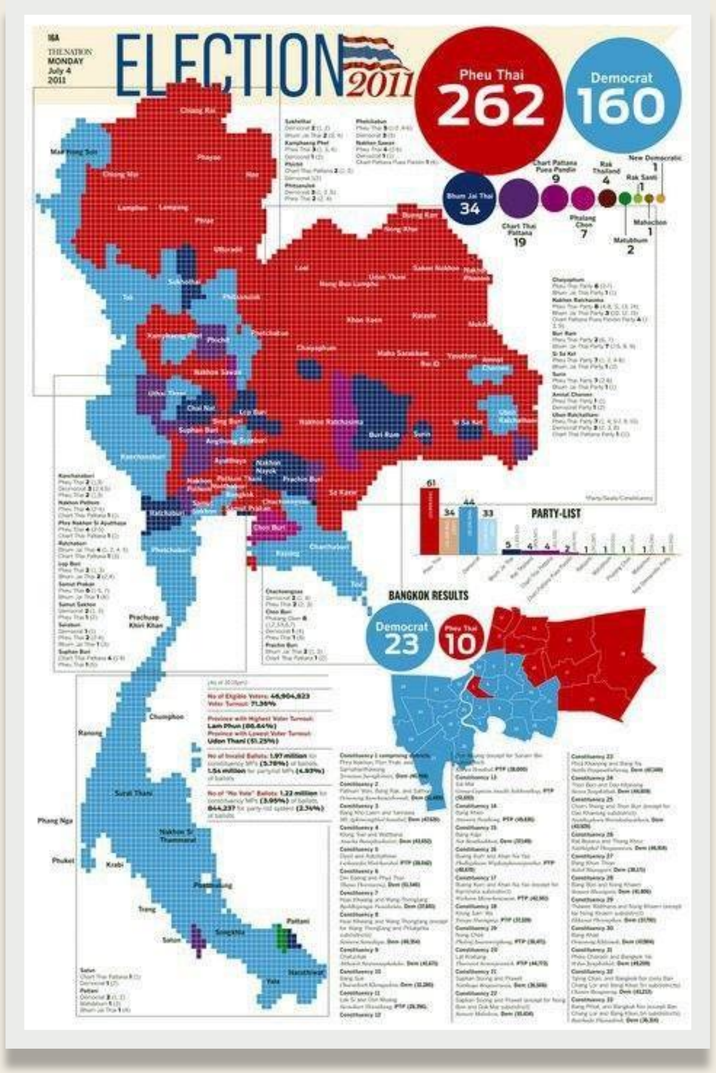
The next few slides
feature graphic content

AN ILLUSTRATION: THAILAND'S 'RED SHIRTS'



Brief intro: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zhMsw5cTH7w

THAILAND'S 'RED SHIRTS'



Formed after a military coup removed popular Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra on 19 September 2006. Become a force in 2008-2009, after the palace, the military, and the judiciary overturned another election, dissolving ruling party backed by Thaksin.

Press demands such as popular sovereignty, equal rights, democracy, end of influence of unelected institutions. Draw most of their support from lower middle class in Bangkok and in North and Northeast of the country.

Large protests staged in between March-May 2010; military crackdown resulted in 90+ deaths. Then helped Yingluck Shinawatra win the 2011 elections.

THAILAND'S 'RED SHIRTS'



The Red Shirts appropriated or created a number of symbols to reinforce collective identification among supporters with diverse backgrounds (class, region, dialect, political ideology).

The color red was chosen because the red stripe in the Thai flag stands for the people. Also appropriated the word phrai (ไพร่) as an identifier.

Until 1905, phrai were commoners required to register with the King or with a master and perform 3-6 months of unpaid labor each year (instead of paying taxes). Abolition in 1905 formally acknowledged everyone as full persons under the law.

The R.S. appropriated this word in 2010 to symbolize that the fight for equal citizenship is not yet finished, foster common identity among its supporters who feel treated as second-class citizens.



In March 2010, the Red Shirts got a lot of attention from the domestic/ national media when they decided to collect blood from their supporters.



In March 2010, the Red Shirts got a lot of attention from the domestic/ national media when they decided to collect blood from their supporters.



Then they carried the blood around, spilling it in front of the Government House, at the house of the Prime Minister at the time (Abhisit Vejjajiva), and at the headquarters of his party, in rituals presided over by Brahmanical priest.



Then they carried the blood around, spilling it in front of the Government House, at the house of the Prime Minister at the time (Abhisit Vejjajiva), and at the headquarters of his party, in rituals presided over by Brahmanical priest.



Much speculation about what these rituals exactly symbolized. Perhaps two things in particular:

1) Asking individual people to shed blood for the movement to increase commitment and mix it with the blood of others to foster solidarity, “oneness” of movement;



2) To symbolize that the power of the ‘illegitimate’ government and its backers (monarchy, military, bureaucrats, business elites, etc.) was earned through repression and violence (by spilling the blood of the people); helps frame movement’s cries of injustice.